PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #48 · ANXIETY

“If people see me anxious, I won’t be able to handle it.”

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Where it often comes from

Many people were taught that anxiety should be hidden: do not cry, do not shake, do not let them see you struggle. A time they were judged, or a time they felt humiliated, sealed the rule. Social fear and anxiety then join. The lie says that if another person notices, you will not be able to cope, and the relationship or the room will be ruined. Being seen is uncomfortable. It is not the same as being destroyed.

What Scripture teaches

God’s grace is sufficient, and His power is made perfect in weakness. Paul even boasts in weakness so that Christ’s power may rest on him. God has not given a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control. The psalmist is afraid and still trusts. Jesus gives peace and says not to let your heart be troubled. “I am with you” does not expire when another person notices you are anxious. You may feel exposed. You are not forsaken, and you are not required to look calm in order to be held by God.

> *“But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me”* (2 Corinthians 12:9).

Also see

> “For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control” (2 Timothy 1:7).

> “When I am afraid, I put my trust in You” (Psalm 56:3).

> “Peace I leave with you; My peace I give to you. I do not give to you as the world gives. Do not let your hearts be troubled; do not be afraid” (John 14:27).

> “Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness” (Isaiah 41:10).

Common self-statements

- If they see my hands shake, it is over.
- I have to look fine or I will fall apart.
- Everyone will think I am weak or strange.
- I should cancel so no one sees me like this.
- I cannot speak if I might cry or blush.
- God is disappointed that I cannot hide this better.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Deciding what everyone will think if they notice.
- Catastrophizing: Turning being noticed into social ruin.
- Fortune telling: Predicting you will be unable to cope once you are seen.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Either I look perfectly calm or I cannot be there at all.

Challenging questions

- What exactly am I afraid people will see, and then what?
- When has someone seen me struggle and stayed kind?
- Do I require other people to hide their anxiety before I respect them?
- What would "coping" look like if it included being visibly nervous?
- What does God's grace cover that my composure does not?
- Who is one safe person I can stop performing for?

Truth summary

> Being seen while I am anxious is uncomfortable, and it is not a disaster. God's grace is enough for me in front of other people.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

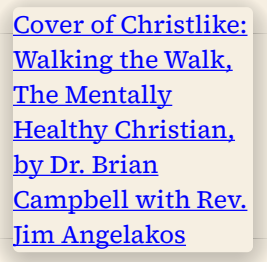
- Anxiety/Worry
- Fear
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Peace
- Church

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Thinking, Healthy

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
You can be honest about anxiety instead of performing calm.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's view of you is not canceled when someone sees you struggle.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
People of faith are meant to welcome a person who is not fine.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
Jesus loves you while you are anxious. Being seen does not erase that.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

My Plan for Replacing "If people see me anxious, I won't be able to handle it."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If people see me anxious, I won't be able to handle it." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly am I afraid people will see, and then what?
- ☐ When has someone seen me struggle and stayed kind?
- ☐ Do I require other people to hide their anxiety before I respect them?
- ☐ What would "coping" look like if it included being visibly nervous?
- ☐ What does God's grace cover that my composure does not?
- ☐ Who is one safe person I can stop performing for?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Being seen while I am anxious is uncomfortable, and it is not a disaster. God's grace is enough for me in front of other people.
- ☐ Someone can notice my anxiety and I can still cope.
- ☐ I do not have to look calm for God to be with me.
- ☐ Grace is sufficient in weakness, including public weakness.
- ☐ Most people are kinder than the disaster I imagine.
- ☐ I can be honest with one safe person.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me."
- ☐ 2 Timothy 1:7
  "For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control."
- ☐ Psalm 56:3
  "When I am afraid, I put my trust in You."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ When being seen felt unbearable: Each day, write down one moment when you wanted to hide your anxiety. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 2 Corinthians 12:9 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God's grace is sufficient for me, even if someone sees that I am anxious.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Anxiety/Worry" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- ☐ Stay while noticed. Attend one small gathering or meeting you would skip, and remain even if you feel visibly nervous. Write what people actually did.
- ☐ Tell one safe person you get anxious, in a single sentence. Notice that the sentence did not ruin you.
- ☐ Drop one disguise. Skip one behavior you use only to look calm, if it is safe to do so, and see what happens.
- ☐ Read 2 Corinthians 12:9 before a situation where you fear being seen.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If people see me anxious, I won't be able to handle it.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A time I was seen and still all right
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If people see me anxious, I won't be able to handle it~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I am afraid of being seen this way. Let Your grace be enough when I cannot look calm. Help me stay, and help me trust that a shaky moment is not the end. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.